
PAKISTAN'S WATER AND MINERAL WATER

MONTHLY BRIEFING

Ten stories from the last two months across sourcing, industry, safety, diplomacy, and access to clean water, with the data behind them

COVERAGE WINDOW: JULY TO SEPTEMBER 2026

Compiled from public reporting. Every item links to its original source.

Dawn · The Express Tribune · ProPakistani · APP (Associated Press of Pakistan) · The Nation · Business Recorder · Aurora (Dawn) · PamirTimes · Energy Update Pakistan

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Ten developments in Pakistan's water and mineral water landscape from the past two months, grouped into five themes, from northern spring sources to national policy. Charts and photo links are included throughout for a fuller picture.

Northern Springs and Sourcing

Where mineral and spring water brands draw from in Gilgit-Baltistan, and what the science says about it.

Industry and Business

A global brand shakeup and a big infrastructure bet, both reshaping who supplies Pakistan's water.

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Access and Relief

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200 mg/L vs. 25,000 to 30,000 mg/L

Typical Total Dissolved Solids in Hunza's mountain freshwater, compared with saline groundwater in Cholistan

Saiqa Imran, Director, National Water Quality Laboratory, PCRWR, APP, Sept 7, 2026

Northern Springs and Sourcing

Where mineral and spring water brands draw from in Gilgit-Baltistan, and what the science says about it.

1 Brand Spotlight: Spring Water Sourced Near Hunza

[Brand feature | Aurora \(Dawn\), company materials](#)

Pura Spring, a Pakistani-owned brand, draws its water from a protected spring at Guru Jaglot near Hunza in Gilgit-Baltistan. Founder Zeeshan Hanif has said the site was chosen after a survey of northern springs, and a bottling plant was built directly beside it so the water is filled close to its source rather than trucked elsewhere for processing.

The brand reports a naturally high pH of roughly 7.2 to 8 and says its plant follows WHO guidelines and holds ISO certification. It positions itself as a homegrown alternative to imported spring waters such as Evian and Fiji, which can spend two to three months in transit before reaching Pakistani shelves. Distribution has so far relied on direct delivery to several hundred retail points rather than large distributors.

[Read more at Aurora \(Dawn\)](#)

2 Why Northern Freshwater Tests So Differently

[Sept 7, 2026 | Associated Press of Pakistan](#)

A PCRWR water quality expert explained that Total Dissolved Solids readings vary enormously by region. Freshwater in Hunza typically measures around 200 milligrams per litre, Islamabad's water generally falls between 300 and 600, and groundwater in Cholistan can reach 25,000 to 30,000 milligrams per litre.

The expert noted this is why a single filtration approach cannot be applied uniformly across the country, and that Pakistan's national drinking water standard allows TDS levels up to 1,000 milligrams per litre, a threshold northern spring sources clear with considerable room to spare.

[Read more at APP](#)

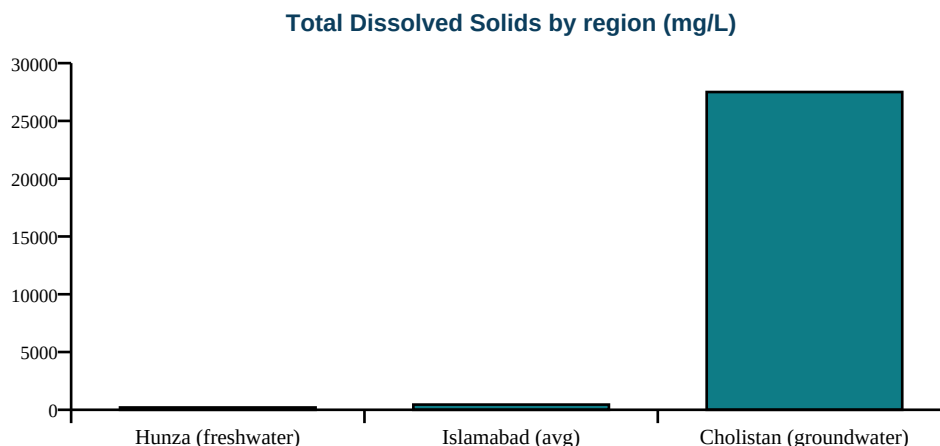


Figure 1: Regional TDS levels, illustrating the gap between mountain freshwater and saline groundwater.

Industry and Business

A global brand shakeup and a big infrastructure bet, both reshaping who supplies Pakistan's water.

3 Nestle Spins Off Its Global Water Brands Into a New Company

[July 23, 2026 | ProPakistani](#)

Nestle S.A. has agreed to combine its global water and premium beverage business, including Nestle Pure Life, Perrier, S.Pellegrino and Acqua Panna, into a new, evenly split joint venture with private equity firm Platinum Equity. The combined company, to be called Peranel, will manage more than 30 brands sold across 120 countries.

Nestle Pakistan, a listed subsidiary, notified the Pakistan Stock Exchange of the transaction, which is expected to close in the first half of 2027 subject to regulatory approval and employee consultations. Nestle Pure Life is one of the largest bottled water brands sold in Pakistan.

[Read more at ProPakistani](#)

4 Rs172 Billion K-IV Scheme Gets Final Approval

[Aug 6 to 7, 2026 | Dawn](#)

The Central Development Working Party approved a sharply revised budget of roughly Rs172 billion for the Greater Karachi Bulk Water Supply Scheme, known as K-IV, a project meant to reduce the city's reliance on costly private water tankers. The cost has climbed by close to 975 percent since contracts were first awarded in 2022, while the planned capacity has been cut by two thirds, from 650 million gallons a day to 260 million.

WAPDA's chairman told a parliamentary panel that financing problems caused the delays; completion is now expected by June 2027, more than 13 years behind the scheme's original schedule.

[Read more at Dawn](#)

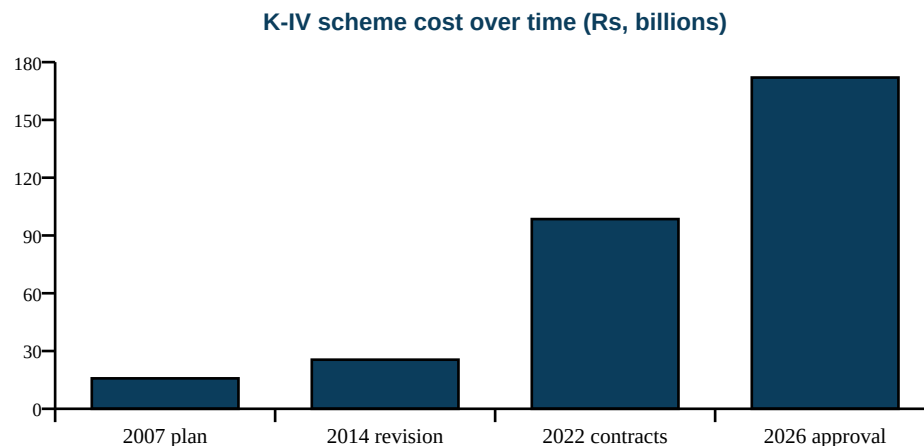


Figure 2: How the K-IV scheme's approved budget has grown across successive revisions.

Quality and Safety

Fresh lab results and a rising household gadget, both circling the same question of what's really in the bottle.

5 Regulator Flags 29 Bottled Water Brands as Unsafe

[Aug 22 to 24, 2026 | Dawn, ProPakistani](#)

The Pakistan Council of Research in Water Resources tested 230 samples from 20 cities collected between April and June, comparing results against Pakistan Standards and Quality Control Authority benchmarks. It found 29 brands unsafe, with 22 of those showing bacterial contamination.

That is a modest improvement on the previous quarter, when 35 of 228 brands sampled nationwide were found unsafe, suggesting the underlying quality problem is persistent but not worsening.

[Read more at ProPakistani](#)

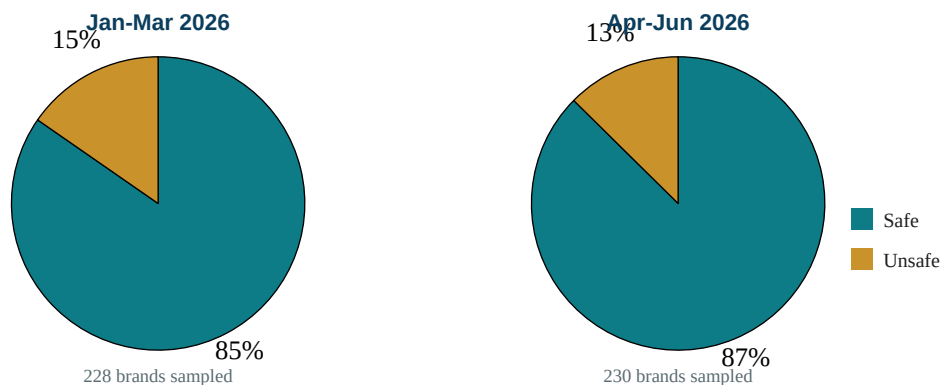


Figure 3: Share of sampled bottled water brands rated safe versus unsafe, by quarter.

6 TDS Testing Pens Catch On With Islamabad Households

Sept 2 to 3, 2026 | [APP](#), [ProPakistani](#)

Pocket-sized digital TDS meters, priced from under Rs1,000, are increasingly showing up in Islamabad homes as people try to check tap and filtered water for themselves, a trend tied to growing household reliance on filtration plants, bottled water and reverse osmosis systems.

A PCRWR laboratory director cautioned that a TDS reading only reflects dissolved salts and minerals. It cannot detect bacteria, viruses, arsenic, fluoride, nitrate or other specific contaminants, so it is no substitute for a full safety test.

[Read more at ProPakistani](#)

Water Diplomacy and Governance

A treaty ruling and a structural critique of who is actually accountable for Pakistan's water.

7 Hague Tribunal: Indus Waters Treaty Still Fully Binding

Aug 31 to Sept 1, 2026 | [The Express Tribune](#)

The Permanent Court of Arbitration at The Hague ruled that India cannot unilaterally suspend the 1960 Indus Waters Treaty, rejecting the grounds India cited for placing it in abeyance since April 2025 following the Pahalgam attack. Alongside its award on the treaty's status, the tribunal issued interim measures restricting construction at the Ratle Hydroelectric Plant on the Chenab River.

India has rejected the ruling outright, saying the tribunal was illegally constituted and has no jurisdiction over its sovereign decisions. Pakistan's foreign ministry says the treaty remains fully applicable and binding, and has called on India for constructive dialogue.

[Read more at The Express Tribune](#)

8 Opinion: The Institutions Exist, the Coordination Doesn't

Sept 10, 2026 | [The Nation](#)

An opinion piece argues Pakistan is not short on water bodies. WAPDA, IRSA and the provinces each play a defined role, but the country lacks a clear, enforceable chain of accountability linking them together, so responsibility for failures is easy to diffuse.

That critique echoes a separate concern raised earlier this year, when two of IRSA's five board seats, including its Sindh member, sat vacant heading into a critical seasonal water allocation meeting, a gap commentators said undercut the authority's own legitimacy at a sensitive moment.

[Related reading at Business Recorder](#)

Access and Relief

Where provincial and community efforts are putting new money and infrastructure to work.

9 Punjab Expands Its Free Clean Water Program

Aug 6 to 7, 2026 | The Express Tribune, ProPakistani

Chief Minister Maryam Nawaz Sharif rejected a proposal to charge for bottled drinking water under the CM Punjab Clean Drinking Water Project, reaffirming it as a free public service. The pilot currently covers four districts: Khushab, Dera Ghazi Khan, Rahim Yar Khan and Bahawalpur, where bottling plants already supply thousands of free 19 litre bottles a day by truck, led by the Khushab facility's capacity of up to 50,000 bottles an hour.

Officials also outlined plans for hundreds more filtration and bottling plants and thousands of new distribution points provincewide, with the wider program aiming to eventually benefit more than 29 million residents in areas where groundwater is contaminated with arsenic or excessive salinity.

[Read more at The Express Tribune](#)

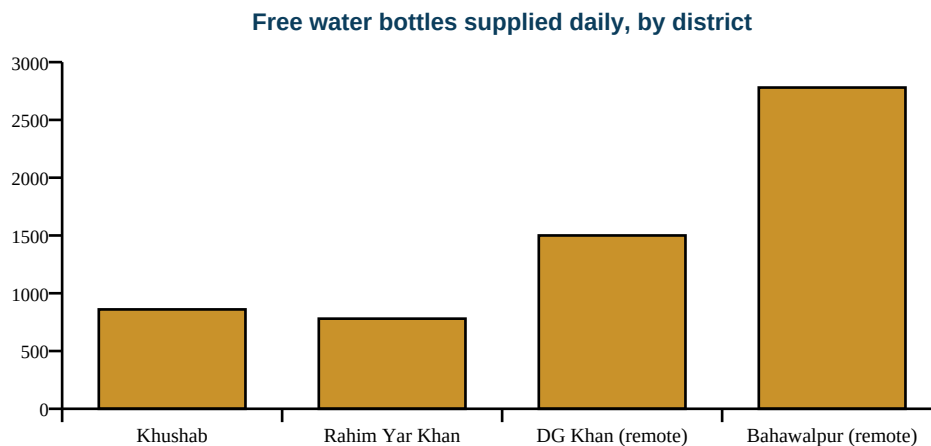


Figure 4: Free drinking water bottles distributed daily under the pilot, by district.

10 A Pipeline Study for Central Hunza's Water Shortage

Ongoing | PamirTimes

Central Hunza's most populous settlements currently depend on two glacial melt streams, Hassanabad Nallah and Ultar Nallah, for their water supply. Recent glacial lake outburst floods have disrupted that supply, even as tourism growth adds further pressure on the same resource.

The Aga Khan Agency for Habitat and the Gilgit-Baltistan government are studying a long-proposed 32 kilometre pipeline from Attabad Lake to serve central Hunza, alongside a hazard and risk assessment for the settlements it would supply. A related Rs1.27 billion project for the pipeline has previously been approved by the Central Development Working Party.

[Read more at PamirTimes](#)

Sources are credited beneath each item and linked for the full story and original photography. This briefing paraphrases and summarizes public reporting for a quick read format.

PHOTOS AND FURTHER READING

This briefing uses original charts rather than reproducing copyrighted news photography. For images of the places and events covered, see the linked articles above, or search: "Hunza valley Gilgit-Baltistan", "Attabad Lake", "Karachi K-IV water project", "Indus River Pakistan", or "PCRWR water testing laboratory".